

Why Electoral Democracy Fails to Redistribute: Caste, Religion and Politics of Identity in India

Introduction

One of the most logical assumptions in political economy is that democracy and redistribution go hand in hand. If the poor outnumber the rich, and in most societies they do, then democratic competition should, in theory, produce governments that tax the wealthy and redistribute to the majority. This is the core logic of the Meltzer-Richard model (1981), arguably the most influential framework in the study of redistributive politics. It predicts that in unequal societies, the median voter — whose income falls below the mean — will consistently support parties that promise redistribution, and that electoral democracy will force governments to deliver it.

India offers one of the most compelling challenges to this prediction. As the world's largest democracy with universal adult suffrage since 1950, it is also one of the most unequal nations in the world today. The top 1% of Indians hold approximately 40% of the country's total wealth, while the bottom 50% account for just 3% (World Inequality Database, 2024). Scheduled Caste earnings average just 55% of those of relatively advantaged social groups, and nearly 905 million people lack access to piped water (PMC, 2021). If the Meltzer-Richard logic held, India's poor majority should have long ago voted in governments committed to aggressive redistribution. They have not — at least not consistently or effectively. The question is why.

This essay argues that the answer lies not in institutional failure alone, but in the way political identity — caste, class, and increasingly religion — shapes what people actually want from the state, and which political alliances democratic competition ends up creating. Drawing on Dr Pavithra Suryanarayan's work on status-threat voting, B.R. Ambedkar's theory of caste and democracy, and the evolving electoral sociology of post-2014 India, I argue that identity does not simply distort redistributive preferences — it constitutes them.

Limits of the Meltzer-Richard Economic Voting Modeling

The Meltzer-Richard model rests on a simple assumption: voters evaluate parties primarily on the basis of their economic interests, and that the poor, being the majority, will support redistribution. This assumption, however, fails empirically across a range of democratic contexts. A comprehensive re-analysis of redistributive politics across affluent democracies found that the mean-to-median income ratio has a consistent, negative, and highly significant effect on redistribution — directly contradicting the model's central premise (Machtei, Huber and Stephens, 2025).

In India, the failure of this framework is even more pronounced. India's growth story since liberalisation has been characterised by widening inequality and a failure of the state to lift its citizens out of poverty, despite decades of electoral competition (CASI, 2024). Labour's income share declined from 32% in the 1990s to approximately 22% by 2024 (ILO). Public health expenditure has remained at around 1% of GDP, leaving 85% of the population without health expenditure support as recently as 2017-18 (PMC, 2021). These are not the outcomes of a democracy efficiently aggregating the preferences of its poor majority.

What the economic voting model misses is that voters do not arrive at the ballot box as abstract income percentiles. They arrive as members of castes and religious communities that structure not just their material circumstances but their political identities and their understanding of what the state owes them. In India this is a central feature of democratic politics.

Caste, Status, and Politics of Anti-Redistribution

One academic account of why poor voters in India support anti-redistribution parties comes from Dr Pavithra Suryanarayan's 2019 paper, *When Do the Poor Vote for the Right Wing and Why?* According to Dr Suryanarayan, in hierarchical societies characterised by high social-status inequality, poor voters from historically dominant groups will support right-wing, anti-redistribution parties to protect their social status.

Dr. Suryanarayan tests this using the 1990 Mandal Commission announcement — the Indian government's decision to implement affirmative action reservations for lower castes in government employment. Using uniquely digitised data from the 1931 census merged with state-level electoral outcomes, she shows that constituencies where Brahmins had historically dominated education saw a significantly larger surge in BJP vote share after the announcement than other areas. Crucially, this pattern did not exist in elections held before the threat materialised.

The mechanism she identifies has two dimensions. The first is psychic: Brahmins derive emotional and social rewards from their rank in the caste hierarchy — ritual prestige, social networks, access to ceremonies and shared spaces — and these rewards hold greater value for poor Brahmins, for whom status is one of the few advantages they possess over lower-caste groups. The second is material: status goods such as segregated schools, temples, and professional networks have real economic value, and their redistribution to lower-caste groups represents a genuine material loss for those who controlled them.

This reframes the redistribution question in an important way. Poor Brahmins were not acting against their own interests — they were protecting a different kind of interest, one rooted in social rank rather than income. As Dr. Suryanarayan argues, they were “rationally seeking to protect their status which holds both economic and social benefits, even if the material component doesn't completely compensate what they could gain from state-led redistribution.”

The implications for democratic theory are significant. If a substantial portion of the poor electorate evaluates redistribution not as a transfer from rich to poor but as a threat to the social order they benefit from, then the Meltzer-Richard prediction collapses. Democratic competition does not produce redistribution — it produces the defence of whichever social hierarchy commands the loyalty of a viable electoral coalition.

The Double-Edged Sword: Identity as Both Tool and Obstacle

It would be a mistake, however, to conclude from Dr. Suryanarayan's work that political identity is simply an obstacle to redistribution in India. The same force that mobilised upper-caste Brahmins against the Mandal Commission has, at other moments, driven some of the most significant redistributive gains in Indian democratic history.

B.R. Ambedkar, the architect of India's constitution and the defining intellectual voice of Dalit emancipation, understood this tension clearly. He argued that political democracy must be accompanied by social and economic democracy, and that caste identity — far from being an obstacle to be dissolved — needed to be mobilised as a political instrument before it could be dismantled as a social one (Ambedkar, *Annihilation of Caste*, 1936). The rise of the Bahujan Samaj Party in Uttar Pradesh, which brought Mayawati to the Chief Ministership four times and forced mainstream parties to engage seriously with Dalit interests, is the most visible expression of this logic in action.

Ambedkar was also prescient about the dangers of democracy in a hierarchical society. He warned that in deeply stratified contexts, democracy could become “the tyranny of the majority,” where upper

castes used electoral numbers to perpetuate dominance rather than dismantle it. His insistence on constitutional safeguards, reservations, and proportional representation was not a concession to identity politics — it was a recognition that formal democratic equality meant nothing without structural redistribution of power.

Political identity in India is therefore double-edged. It has been the vehicle through which marginalised groups have demanded redistribution and forced the state to respond. It has simultaneously been deployed to build anti-redistribution coalitions among groups whose social position makes them resistant to redistributive politics even when their income would suggest otherwise.

Post 2014: When Religion Replaces Caste

Dr Suryanarayan's framework is analytically powerful for understanding the 1990 Mandal moment, but India's political landscape has shifted significantly since then — in ways that raise new questions about the mechanisms through which identity shapes redistribution.

Dr Suryanarayan's own 2004 survey data showed Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe voters as the least likely of all caste groups to vote for the BJP, sitting at a predicted probability of just 0.15 in high Brahman-dominance constituencies. The status-threat argument would predict this: SC/ST voters have no historical status to protect, and should therefore have no reason to support an anti-redistribution, right-wing party.

Yet by the 2019 general elections, approximately one third of Dalits and over 37% of OBC voters cast their ballots for the BJP (Lokniti-CSDS, 2019). This is a striking departure from the patterns her framework predicts. What changed?

Scholars like Pratap Bhanu Mehta have argued that the BJP has increasingly mobilised voters not through caste-based status appeals but through a unified Hindu religious identity — one that cuts across caste boundaries and creates a different kind of cross-group coalition, built not on shared social rank but on shared religious belonging (Mehta, 2022). This represents a mechanism that Suryanarayan's status-threat framework was not designed to explain.

The distinction matters enormously for public policy. If anti-redistribution coalitions in India were solely a product of caste-based status threat, then the policy response would focus on reducing the psychic and material value of caste hierarchy — through education, integration, and the enforcement of constitutional equality. But if the more recent dynamic is driven by a constructed religious identity that transcends caste, the mechanisms are different and the policy implications are less clear. A shared religious identity can mobilise voters across income and caste lines in ways that are harder to disaggregate and harder to address through conventional redistributive policy.

This does not invalidate Dr Suryanarayan's core insight — that identity shapes redistributive preferences in ways that the economic voting model cannot account for. It simply extends it. The question is no longer simply why poor upper-caste voters resist redistribution, but why the very lower-caste voters who were predicted to demand it are increasingly aligning with parties that do not deliver it.

Conclusion: Governance, Identity, and the Redistribution Gap

India's redistribution failure is not, at its core, a technical problem. It is a political one. The country has the institutional architecture of a democracy, a constitution with strong redistributive commitments, and a poor majority with obvious economic incentives to demand more from the state. What it lacks is

a stable political coalition committed to redistribution that is capable of winning and sustaining power against the identity-based coalitions that democratic competition has repeatedly produced.

Post-independence reforms, though grounded in democratic ideals, often took a top-down form that prioritised the interests of rural capitalists and dominant castes. Democracy alone, as Dr Ambedkar understood, is not a sufficient condition for redistribution. It is a terrain on which social forces compete — and in a society structured by caste and, increasingly, religious identity, those forces do not always align with the interests of the poor.

The Meltzer-Richard model assumes that voters are atomised income-maximisers. In India, they are members of communities with histories, hierarchies, and social interests that do not reduce to income. Understanding why redistribution fails here requires taking seriously not just what people earn, but who they are — and who they are told they are by the parties competing for their votes. This is, ultimately, a question about the relationship between democracy and equality. Not whether democracy can produce equality in theory, but under what political, institutional, and social conditions it actually does. India remains one of the most important and instructive cases through which to examine that question — and the answers it offers are neither simple nor comfortable.

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